

Feeding

Bats have a wide variety of food sources. Most bats eat insects and can consume huge amounts in one night. The smaller bats, such as pipistrelles, catch tiny gnats and mosquitoes. Larger bats, such as noctules and serotines, feed on cockchafers and dung beetles. Some bats pounce on prey that is on the ground, and pick insects off leaves. Fruit-eating bats live mostly in the tropics, where they have a year-round supply of food.

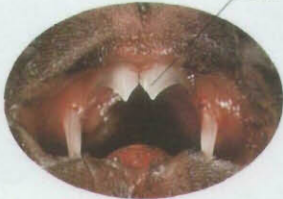


Vampire bats

True vampire bats feed on the blood of mammals or birds. Using their razor-like incisor teeth, they make a wound on an ear or ankle. As the blood flows, the vampire bat drinks it with a grooved tongue that acts like a drinking straw.

Bat drinking from a donkey.

Incisor teeth



Bulldog bat

Fishing bats trail their long legs in the water to catch a fish.

Fishing bats

Some bats use echolocation to detect fish just below the water's surface. Fishing bats have long legs and they fly along the surface and catch the fish with long, sharp claws.



Bats will only eat the pulp of the fruit.

Fruit bats

These bats squash ripe fruit against ridges on the roof of their mouth. They spit out the rind and large seeds that are difficult to digest. Fruit bats sometimes eat the fruit in the tree where they pick it, but they may carry it to a safe roost to eat.

Spectacled flying fox



False vampire bat

The bat finds its prey using echolocation.

Meat-eating bats

Many larger microbats catch and eat mice, rats, frogs, and lizards. False vampire bats from Asia and America carry their catch to a suitable perch to devour it, using their thumbs and wing membranes to hold the heavy prey.



Some nectar-feeding bats hover above the flower.

Glossophagine bat

Nectar feeders

Trees that are pollinated by bats provide the animals with nectar and pollen as a reward for their services. The tongues of nectar-feeding bats have a brush-like tip which the bats use to lap up the nectar and pollen inside the flowers.

Nursery

Like all true mammals, a female bat carries her young inside her womb until she gives birth. Usually, only one bat is born at a time to minimize the extra weight a pregnant female has to carry in flight. Females gather, often in large numbers, to give birth in a nursery roost.

This nursery roost is in the roof of a building.

Young bats are born pink and hairless, so they need warm surroundings.

Young bats hang upside-down while their mothers go out to feed.

A large number of bats together keep each other warm.

Females suckle their young hanging upside-down. The young cling to their mother with their teeth and claws.

Most young bats cannot fly until they are three weeks old.

Each female bat can recognize the squeak of her own young.

Threats and predators

This red-tailed racer from Southeast Asia, also known as a mangrove ratsnake, catches bats in the tops of mangrove trees. Other animals that prey on bats include bat hawks, owls, and cats. Some of the greatest threats to the survival of bats around the world are habitat destruction, pesticides, and human vandalism. Many species are in danger of extinction.

Ratsnake hunts at night.



Largest and smallest

The largest bat is a Malaysian flying fox which can have a wingspan of up to 1.7 m (5.6 ft). The smallest bat is the bumblebee bat, also known as Kitt's hog-nosed bat. This tiny animal is only about 30 mm (1 in) long and weighs only 2 g (0.07 oz).



GREATER HORSESHOE BAT

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Rhinolophus ferrumequinum*

ORDER Chiroptera

FAMILY Rhinolophidae

DISTRIBUTION Central and southern Europe, North Africa across to Japan

HABITAT Woodland, pasture, human settlements

DIET Insects

SIZE Length: 6–7 cm (2.4–2.75 in)

LIFESPAN Up to 30 years

FIND OUT MORE

CAVE WILDLIFE

CONSERVATION

HIBERNATION

MAMMALS

WHALES AND DOLPHINS